

Crested Gecko Care Guide

Correlophus ciliatus

Difficulty: Easy

Crested geckos are medium-sized (6-8 in long) lizards that vary widely in color and pattern. They have broad adhesive toe pads with small claws that let them climb smooth surfaces, along with the characteristic crest running from above the eyes down the back. They are native to New Caledonia and commonly live 15-20 years with proper care.

Shopping List

- Front-opening 18 x 18 x 24 in glass terrarium
- 10-25 W ceramic heater, depending on ambient temperature
- 5.5 in dome lamp with ceramic socket
- Plug-in light timer
- Infrared thermometer
- Pressure sprayer
- Reptile-safe water conditioner
- Digital thermometer/hygrometer
- 2-4 in organic soil or similar substrate
- Decor such as vines, coconut hides, and foliage
- Feeding ledge with cups
- Small feeding cups
- Feeding tongs
- Complete crested gecko diet powder
- Calcium supplement

Housing

Crested geckos are arboreal and need a vertically oriented enclosure that allows climbing, exploration, hunting, and other natural behaviors. A strongly recommended adult enclosure size is 18 x 18 x 24 in, and larger is preferred when possible.

Young crested geckos under about 12 g may benefit from a smaller temporary grow-out enclosure, around 5 gallons or roughly 12 x 12 x 12 in, until they are large enough to safely navigate the adult enclosure.

Lighting and UVB

Crested geckos are crepuscular and tend to be most active around dusk and at night. If UVB is provided, use an appropriate low-output source such as an Arcadia ShadeDweller or Zoo Med ReptiSun 5.0 above mesh, positioned according to the manufacturer's guidance. Supplementation should be adjusted to the UVB setup so vitamin D3 is not over-supplied.

Heating

Crested geckos thermoregulate by moving between warmer and cooler areas.

- Basking area: 82-85 F (28-29 C)
- Cool zone: 70-75 F (21-24 C)

- Night: 65-72 F (18-22 C)

Create the basking area with a vine, branch, or foliage cluster below the heat source. In a tall enclosure the warmest area will generally be toward the top and the coolest toward the bottom, so provide usable perches and cover at several heights. Monitor temperatures with reliable digital instruments.

Humidity

Maintain a humid but well-ventilated environment, generally averaging about 60-80% relative humidity with normal daily drying cycles. Mist as needed, commonly morning and evening, both to raise humidity and to provide droplets for drinking. Use appropriately treated tap water rather than relying only on distilled water.

Substrate

Because crested geckos spend most of their time above ground, substrate mainly helps manage humidity, waste, and fall cushioning. One practical mix is about 40% organic topsoil, 40% coco coir, and 20% untreated sphagnum moss, optionally topped with cleaned leaf litter.

Remove feces, urates, and visibly contaminated substrate promptly. Replace the full substrate as needed, commonly every 1-3 months depending on the setup.

Food

Crested geckos are omnivores. A high-quality complete crested gecko diet should be the staple, supplemented with appropriately sized live insects.

Suitable feeder insects include crickets and dubia roaches, with items such as mealworms or small hornworms used more occasionally.

Typical feeding frequency:

- Hatchlings and juveniles, 0-12 months: complete diet daily; insects 1-2 times per week
- Adults over 12 months: complete diet every 2-3 days; insects about once per week

Supplements

Complete crested gecko diets are already fortified. Feeder insects should be lightly dusted with calcium so the overall calcium-to-phosphorus balance remains appropriate. If UVB is used, choose supplementation that avoids unnecessary vitamin D3. If UVB is not used, a calcium supplement containing D3 may be appropriate.

Decor and Enrichment

Provide climbing and hiding opportunities such as hanging coconut hides, vines, branches, bamboo, artificial or live foliage, and elevated hides or ledges. A varied enclosure encourages movement and natural behavior.

Cohabitation

Cohabitation is generally not recommended for novice keepers. Even females that appear compatible can become aggressive or compete for resources. Males should never be housed together. The safest default is one crested gecko per enclosure.

Red Rocks Exotic Reptiles care information is educational support only. Continue researching current high-quality husbandry sources and consult a reptile-experienced veterinarian for illness, injury, breathing difficulty, neurological

signs, or prolonged appetite loss.